

The trial funnel

Week 6, Lecture 2 · LangoBee to \$10K MRR

Summer 2026 · Operating a Solo Language App from Zero Revenue

What we'll cover

- CC-required vs CC-optional: what the conversion data actually shows
- Trial length: why 14 days is defensible and how to test whether it is right
- The trial funnel in LangoBee: Stripe checkout through to PostHog event
- Why zero trial_started events is a code problem and a funnel problem
- The section task: make the event fire once, verified in PostHog

CC-required vs CC-optional

The conversion case for CC-required

Benchmarks from Poyar's 2026 survey of 200 software products:

- **CC-optional free trial:** ~8% free-to-paid conversion
- **CC-required free trial:** 25-35% (good) to 50-60% (great) free-to-paid conversion

CC-required converts 3-7x better because the user who enters their card is signaling intent, not curiosity. They have already passed a commitment test.

The objection: you lose people at the card step. True. But at LangoBee's current acquisition volume (174 Discord-recruited direct visitors/30d), you need each entrant to convert at the highest possible rate. Low-volume acquisition amplifies the value of high-intent filtering.

(Poyar, 2026)

What CC-required actually tests

CC-required trial tests a specific belief: that the product is strong enough that a stranger will enter their card to try it.

That is a high bar at pre-validation scale.

If nobody enters their card, you have learned one of three things:

1. Awareness is the bottleneck (nobody reaches the paywall)
2. Perceived value is too low (they reach it and bounce)
3. Price is the barrier (they would try it but not at \$7.99/mo)

The only way to distinguish these three is to get one person through the funnel and look at where the others dropped off. You cannot do that with zero events.

Trial length: 14 days

The 14-day trial is a common default but not the only option.

Evidence from RevenueCat's 2025 State of Subscription Apps report:

- Trials longer than 17 days convert at 45.7% vs shorter trials
- 82% of trial starts occur on day 0 (the day of signup)
- Most churn from trials happens in the first 3 days if the product fails to activate

For a language app: 14 days is enough time to complete several reading or video sessions. Whether it is the right length is an empirical question. The test is: do users who complete at least one session in the first 3 days convert at higher rates than those who do not?

LangoBee cannot answer that question yet because there are no trial_started events.

The trial funnel in LangoBee

What "fully wired" means

As of June 2026, the following are live in LangoBee:

- Stripe Checkout configured for \$7.99/mo and \$49/yr plans
- 14-day trial period set on both price objects
- Stripe webhooks configured to receive checkout.session.completed
- PostHog initialized in the Next.js app with `phc_` API key

What is missing: a `posthog.capture('trial_started', {...})` call anywhere in the codebase. The infrastructure exists. The event is not being fired.

The session this week has one job: make that call fire once and verify it in PostHog Live Events.

Where the call goes

The correct place for the `trial_started` event is the Stripe webhook handler, not the client-side checkout redirect.

Reason: a client-side redirect fires only if the user lands on the success page. A webhook fires when Stripe confirms the checkout session server-side. Only the webhook is reliable.

```
Event: checkout.session.completed
→ Handler: apps/web/src/app/api/stripe/webhook/route.ts
→ Condition: session.mode === 'subscription'
              && session.subscription !== null
→ Call: posthog.capture('trial_started', {
    distinctId: userId,
    properties: {
      plan: priceId,
      price: amount,
      trial_length_days: 14,
    }
  })
```

Properties to attach to trial_started

Minimum viable set for the first event:

Property	Value	Why
plan	Stripe price ID	Distinguishes monthly from annual
price_usd	7.99 or 4.08 (49/yr normalized)	Enables revenue segmentation
trial_length_days	14	Documents the trial window at time of fire
source	UTM source or "direct"	Acquisition channel at trial start

Do not over-engineer. Four properties is enough for the first firing. You can add more once the event is flowing.

Freemium vs CC-required: per 1,000 visitors

Freemium path

- ~90 signups
- ~5 paying customers
- 5.6% free-to-paid rate
- High top-of-funnel, low conversion

CC-required trial (LangoBee)

- ~25 trial starts
- ~6-12 paying customers
- 25-50% trial-to-paid rate
- Lower top-of-funnel, higher conversion

At 174 real visitors/30d, the CC-required path produces more paying customers per visitor despite smaller top-of-funnel.

(Poyar, 2026)

A trial requirement filters for intent, not against it. Users who enter a paid trial and engage consistently are the signal worth doubling down on.
(Paraphrased)

Patrick Campbell, Pricing, Retention, and Growth Strategies That Work (2022)

Business of Software USA 2022

Verification: how to confirm the event fired

After wiring the webhook handler:

1. Create a test Stripe Checkout session using Stripe's test mode card `4242 4242 4242 4242`
2. Complete the checkout
3. Open PostHog project 374549 → Activity → Live Events
4. Filter by event name `trial_started`
5. Confirm: the event appears with the correct properties (plan, price_usd, trial_length_days)

If the event does not appear within 60 seconds:

- Check Stripe Dashboard → Webhooks → Recent deliveries for errors
- Check the Next.js server logs for handler exceptions
- Confirm the webhook secret matches what is in `apps/web/.env.local`

Do not mark this task done until the event appears in PostHog Live Events.

Take-aways

1. CC-required trials convert 3-7x better than CC-optional because the card entry filters for intent. At low acquisition volume, high-intent filtering beats broad top-of-funnel.
2. LangoBee's 14-day trial is a reasonable default. Whether it is optimal cannot be tested until trial events are flowing.
3. The trial_started event belongs in the Stripe webhook handler, not the client-side success redirect. Webhooks are reliable; browser redirects are not.
4. Zero trial_started events means there is either a code gap (the event was never wired) or a funnel gap (no real user has reached checkout). Both are likely true right now.
5. The section task this week is not a theory exercise. The deliverable is one real trial_started event visible in PostHog Live Events.

What's next

- **Section this week:** fire the first trial_started event, verify it in PostHog, then run the WTP interview script
- **HW3 "First dollar":** your deliverable is one verified trial_started event in PostHog. Due at the end of this week.
- **Week 7:** paywall placement, paywall copy, and the upgrade trigger: where in the LangoBee session does a paywall feel earned vs hostile?